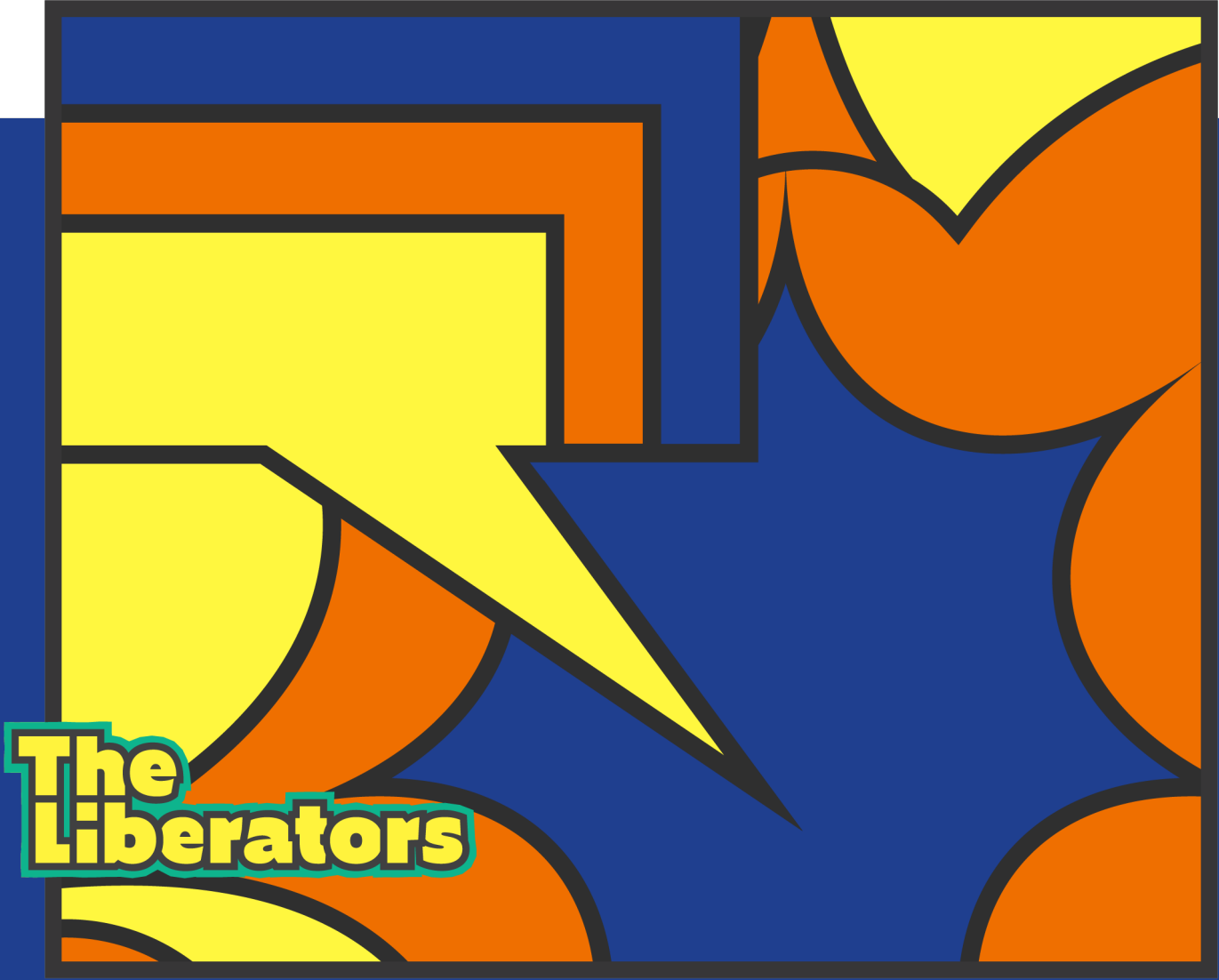


Explore The State Of Your Product And Market Conditions

A do-it-yourself workshop to create a shared understanding about the state of your product and its environment with the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What"

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes include a large yellow arrow pointing right, a yellow rectangle, and several orange and yellow curved shapes. The text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a thick black outline and a slight shadow effect, positioned in the bottom left corner of the graphic.

**The
Liberators**

The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

The better a Scrum team understands its stakeholders and their product, the more likely they are to build the right things. Otherwise, they may end up wasting a lot of time and money on problems that stakeholders don't have. This concern for stakeholders is determined by the quality of Sprint Reviews, the amount of collaboration with stakeholders, a strong focus on valuable outcomes, and product discovery.

In order to achieve this, Scrum teams shouldn't only focus on the product they're building. Together with their stakeholders, they should also pay attention to the market circumstances and the consequences for the product. What is happening in our field of work? What are our users saying? What are competitors building?

The purpose of this workshop is to invite Scrum teams and their stakeholders to focus on the bigger picture. What is happening outside your organization and how does this influence the product your team is developing?

Give this workshop a try during the next Sprint Review!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Flow



Step 1: Opening



5 min

Step 2: What Have We Seen, Heard, And Observed?



25 min

Step 3: So What Does this Mean?



30 min

Step 4: Now What Next Steps Makes Sense?



25 min

Step 5: Closing

5 min

Total duration

90 min

Difficulty / Effort



Required Skill



This workshop uses a basic structure, and shouldn't be difficult to facilitate.

Impact On Survival



A shared understanding about the state of your product and its market circumstances increase the likelihood your product contains the right features and ships at the right moments.



How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward.

Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one Scrum team. Ideally, you involve your stakeholders as well. As such, this template makes an excellent workshop to use during the Sprint Review.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- Collect data about the product and market conditions upfront. Ideally, you do this together with your team. Gather data like a Net Promoter Score, the number of new customers, how many customers left, revenue, profit, competitors, feedback, etc. Have this data available at the start of the workshop. It provides the input for the first part of "What, So What, Now What".

Resources

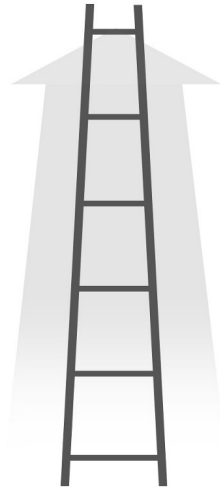
- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Actual stakeholders? Or just your audience? Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)
- Blog post: [Five Types Of Value](#)



About the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What"



Ladder of Inference



I take **actions** based on beliefs

Now What?

I adopt **beliefs** about the world

I draw **conclusions** from assumptions

I make **assumptions** based on meaning

I add cultural & personal **meaning**

So what?

I select **data** from observations

What?



Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz. Based on work by Chris Argyris.

Our human minds aren't very accustomed to the complex, technological world we live in. We employ stereotypes to judge others, we generalize based on small observations and we jump to conclusions without considering the facts. This is especially tricky in the fast-paced environments we work in and the decisions we make there. "What new feature should we invest in for our product?", "Why are we not delivering as rapidly as we should?" and "How can we avoid this incident from happening again?"

'What, So What, Now What' is a foundational Liberating Structure that helps by asking us to step back and consider what is going on. It structures our thinking by breaking our experience down into three steps: "What do we notice?", "So, what does this mean?", and "Now, where do go from here?". It takes inspiration from the [Ladder of Inference](#) by Chris Argyris, an expert on learning in organizations.

By doing this with others, we are encouraged to discover the gaps in our understanding by learning from their perspectives. Being a fairly simple structure, you can easily adapt it to suit the needs of the situation. And the more you do it, the more natural this structured approach to sense-making becomes.

This structure was created by Keith McCandless and Henri Lipmanowicz. And inspired by Chris Argyris and Peter Senge.

Uses In Scrum

- As part of a Sprint Review to digest and make sense of what was delivered during the past Sprint and any feedback that was received, and decide on next steps together;
- To reflect on a critical incident or a team conflict together with the people involved and/or impacted, either during a Sprint or during a Sprint Retrospective;
- Together with developers, to determine what strategies to use for optimizing codebases or reducing technical debt;
- As part of a Sprint Retrospective where members of a team are invited to reflect on how the team worked together



and went about their Sprint;

- To periodically reflect on how the organization is doing in their Agile journey. Invite teams and stakeholders and invite them to reflect on the process so far.

Tips

- 'What, So What, Now What' often feels counter-intuitive at first. The more often you do it, the more natural it becomes;
- Use a talking object to structure the interaction in small groups and to avoid drowning out voices. When only the person holding the object can talk, others can focus on active listening;
- You can use a short version of 'What, So What, Now What' to debrief meetings;
- We often bring a print-out of the ladder of inference to help participants structure their thinking, and avoid jumping up the ladder;
- Use What, So What, Now What on experiences that are fresh. Don't reflect on something that happened a while ago;

Checklist

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Create shared understanding with 'What, So What, Now What'](#)



Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and clarify how the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What" is used as a frame that includes other smaller structures. This only takes a couple of minutes.

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves or to wait for people to drop in.

Step 2: What Have We Seen, Heard, And Observed?

The first part of the Liberating Structure "[What, So What, Now What](#)" is focused on facts and observations. So, no interpretations, assumptions, or conclusions. It's often also helpful to share some examples of facts upfront:

- "We noticed that a competitor recently released a feature we have on our Product Backlog as well";
- "There seem to be 3 competitors who build a similar product";
- "Currently, we have 75 subscribers which result in a monthly revenue of \$500,-";
- "In the past month, we've released our product 3 times to production";
- "Our latest release to production resulted in 5 bugs reported by our users";

Use the Liberating Structure [Impromptu Networking](#) to quickly let everyone share their ideas and thoughts.



Invitation

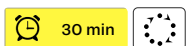
"Given how stakeholders use our product and the market in which our product exists, what have you noticed or observed that seems important?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the first invitation. What did they see, hear or observe? Encourage people to remain as factual as possible, taking the perspective of what an outsider would have noticed;
2. **4 min** Ask everyone to form small pairs to share what they noticed. Encourage them to focus on similarities and differences. If you're doing this virtually, move people into breakouts.
3. **10 min** Repeat the previous round twice more. Invite people into new pairs, and let them share their thoughts and observations while noticing patterns.
4. **10 min** When everyone is back together, ask the participants for the patterns they noticed. Capture them on a shared surface if you want to.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Rapidly share novel ideas and make personal connections with 'Impromptu Networking'](#)



Step 3: So What Does this Mean?

In the previous step, you asked the group to identify facts and observations for the state of the product and its market conditions. Now it's time to turn these facts into interpretations and conclusions. Based on what we've discovered, what does this mean? The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is ideally suited to help the team quickly share their thoughts.

For this step, it's also useful to give some examples in advance:

- "Our competitors seem to release new features faster than us";
- "We don't seem to reach our desired number of subscribers by the end of this year";
- "We need to test better to decrease the number of detected bugs in production";
- "The revenue we gain with our current subscribers is sufficient to cover our costs for maintenance";
- "There aren't many competitors in the market, but the ones that do exist seem to have quite a lot of similarities with our product."



Invitation

"Given what we observed, what does this tell us about the state of our product, its market potential, and our roadmap?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. What conclusions can they draw? What do their observations say about our product and its market conditions?
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace.

Our Findings

- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will. You can always do a second 1-2-4-ALL if you need to go deeper.
- Facilitate the silent self-reflection firmly, before the paired conversations, and invite everyone to write down their ideas. This allows participants to focus and make ideas tangible and specific.

Resources

- Blog post: Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with [1-2-4-ALL](#)
- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website





Step 4: Now What Next Steps Makes Sense?

So far, the group discussed the facts & conversations in the first step and afterward turned them into interpretations and conclusions. Now it's a good moment to close the debrief by identifying improvements and next steps. Again, you'll use the Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) for this.

Invitation

"Given what we observed, what are important course corrections, adjustments, and improvements we should consider for our product?"

Steps

1. **1 min** First individually and in silence, ask people to write down their thoughts on the second invitation. What conclusions can they draw? What do their observations say about our product and its market conditions?
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs to share their ideas and build on them together. If you do this virtually, create breakout rooms for the pairs.
3. **4 min** Ask the pairs to find another pair and share their ideas, and how they built on them, again building on their ideas in a group of four. If you're doing this virtually, move the groups of four into break-out rooms.
4. **8 min** Together, collect the key ideas in a shared workspace.

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Create shared understanding with 'What, So What, Now What'](#)



Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you used the Liberating Structure "What, So What, Now What" to create a shared understanding of the state of your product and its environment. Hopefully, it helped you identify important improvements and adaptations.

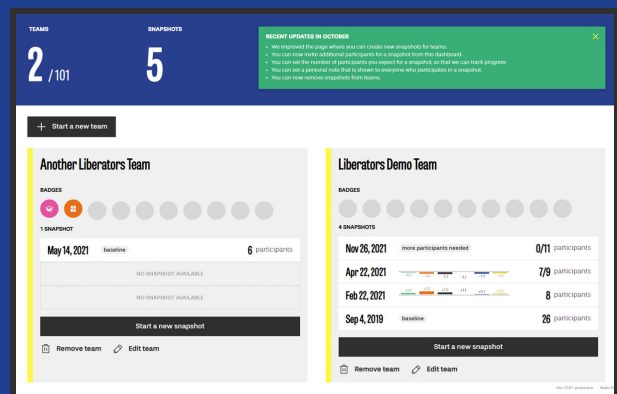
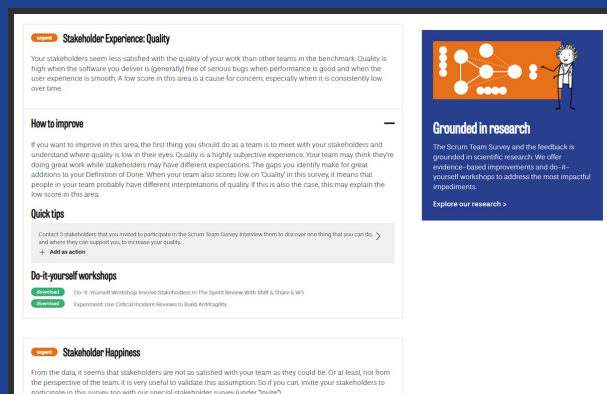
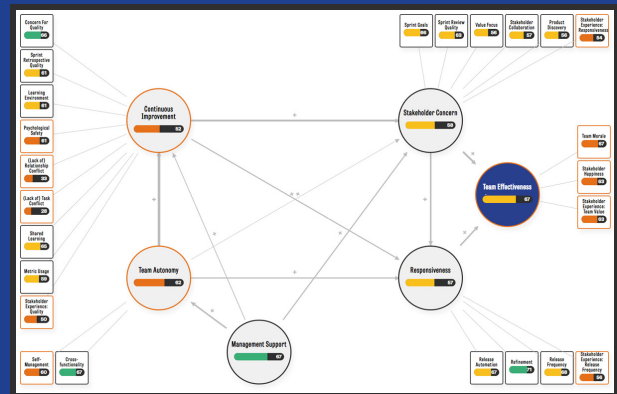
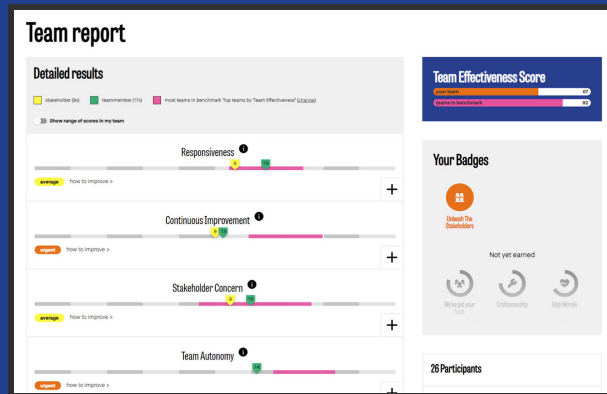
If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

Let's learn and grow, together!



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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